

Affirmative Action in Medical School Admissions

We have discussed in class the significance of having a physician who shares similar cultural background or language, particularly for individuals belonging to minority groups, as seen in the film *Miss Evers' Boys*. The film presents themes which give emphasis to the value of trust and understanding between medical professionals and their patients. In line with this notion, the recent overturning of affirmative action by the US Supreme Court has raised concerns.

Affirmative action is a policy that was put forth to address historical and systemic disadvantages faced by certain minority groups, particularly in education and employment opportunities. It has long been a contentious issue, with proponents arguing that it helps level the playing field and promotes diversity and inclusion, while critics claim it may lead to reverse discrimination or undermine the concept of meritocracy. Nevertheless, DeVille (1999) suggests that affirmative action emerges as a promising strategy to address and overcome issues of distrust.

Canada does not have a formalized policy similar to affirmative action. However, this does not mean that the country is without its own challenges regarding representation and diversity in medical schools. According to Beruar et al. (2020), in a position paper, "[t]here remains underrepresentation of certain racial & ethnic minority groups in medical school, with a specific and concerning underrepresentation of Black and Indigenous medical students, and low socioeconomic diversity with the vast majority of students coming from high socioeconomic backgrounds".

Given the highly rigorous, selective, and costly medical school admission process, how can Canadian medical school admissions standardize the process better ensure a diverse pool of applicants that reflects the rich diversity of the Canadian population, especially for applicants who are underrepresented in medicine? What potential problems might arise from the standardization of the medical schools' admission process? How can we ensure fairness if we were to adopt or implement a similar system to affirmative action, with the main goal being the equality of "opportunity" and not equality of representation nor equality of outcome?

References:

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- DeVille, K. (1999). Trust, patient well-being and affirmative action in medical school admissions. *Mount Sinai Journal of Medicine*, 66, 247-56.